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EDITORIAL

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Conceptualizing and developing teacher language awareness for content and language integration (TLA for CLI) across educational contexts

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ABSTRACT

Teacher language awareness for content and language integration (TLA for CLI) is the special type of knowledge and perception of language required by teachers who teach content through a second or foreign language or combine language and content instruction. This Special Issue examines how TLA for CLIL is conceptualized and developed in diverse settings, from primary to tertiary education, around the world (North and South America, Asia, and Europe). Building on Edge's framework of three domains of language teachers' knowledge (user, analyst, teacher) and Andrews' work on teacher language awareness, the six studies use various theoretical lenses and methodological options to explore TLA for CLI in their respective settings. Key emerging themes include the theory-practice relationship in TLA, the role of collaboration in developing TLA for CLI, the impact of teachers' epistemological beliefs, the importance of critical language awareness, and the need for a plurilingual perspective. After examining the cross-cutting themes in the six studies, the editorial proposes expanding the construct of TLA for CLI to incorporate critical sociolinguistic perspectives, plurilingual competence, and disciplinary literacy.

RESUMEN

La conciencia lingüística del docente para la integración de contenido y lenguaje (CLD para ICL) es el tipo especial de conocimiento y percepción del lenguaje requerido por los docentes que enseñan contenido a través de una segunda lengua o lengua extranjera, o que combinan la instrucción de lenguaje y contenido. Este Número Especial examina cómo se conceptualiza y desarrolla la CLD para ICL en diversos entornos, desde la educación primaria hasta la terciaria, en diferentes partes del mundo (América del Norte y del Sur, Asia y Europa). Basándose en el marco de Edge de tres dominios del conocimiento de los profesores de idiomas (usuario, analista, docente) y en el trabajo de Andrews sobre la conciencia lingüística del docente, los seis estudios utilizan diversas perspectivas teóricas y opciones metodológicas para explorar la CLD para ICL en sus respectivos contextos. Los temas clave emergentes incluyen la relación teoría-práctica en la CLD, el papel de la colaboración en el desarrollo de la CLD para ICL, el impacto de las creencias epistemológicas de los docentes, la importancia de la conciencia lingüística crítica y la necesidad de una perspectiva plurilingüe. Después de examinar los temas transversales en los seis estudios, el editorial propone

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expandir el constructo de CLD para ICL para incorporar perspectivas sociolingüísticas críticas, competencia plurilingüe y alfabetización disciplinar.

PLAIN LANGUAGE SUMMARY

This editorial introduces a collection of six articles about teacher language awareness for content and language integration (TLA for CLI), which is how teachers understand and use language when teaching subjects in a language that is not the students' (or often their own) first language. This happens in many schools and universities worldwide, where subjects like science or history are taught in a second language, or content such as science or history is used in language lessons. The articles look at different types of schools and programmes, from elementary to university level, in various countries in North and South America, Asia and Europe. They explore the kinds of knowledge and awareness teachers need to balance teaching both the subject content and the language. Some key ideas emerge: teachers need both theoretical knowledge about language and the skills to put it into practice; collaboration with other teachers and researchers helps teachers improve their language awareness; teachers' beliefs about language affect how and what they teach; it is important for teachers to think critically about how language is used in its social contexts; teachers need to be aware that learners know and use other languages apart from the language of instruction and use this in their teaching. After analysing the key ideas in the six papers, the editorial suggests that teacher training for teachers who combine content and language teaching should include more focus on critical thinking about language, using multiple languages, and understanding disciplinary literacy – that is, how language works in different subjects.

Introduction

Content and language integration (CLI) refers to the teaching and learning of disciplinary subject-matter through the medium of, or combined with, a second or foreign language. It has become a pressing issue in many educational contexts throughout the world, where teachers are asked to teach non-language content (e.g. mathematics, history, science) through languages of instruction that are not the students' (or often the teachers') first language, or to teach languages through other non-language content. CLI occurs in a range of international contexts covering all levels of K-12 schooling and tertiary education. These programmes come under different labels such as content-based foreign language teaching, immersion, dual language education, content and language integrated learning (CLIL), bilingual education, English Medium Instruction (EMI), and English as an additional language (EAL). Although the extent to which there is an explicit focus or expectation of content and language integration varies across and within programme types, they are usually justified in terms of some kind of extension of learners' plurilingual competence.

One recurring issue across all these different contexts is the perceived lack of adequate initial teacher education and professional development (PD) for teachers. As Ballinger, Tedick et al. (2024) point out, while there has been growing attention to the PD of teachers in CLI contexts, tailored programmes and courses remain rare, teacher educators are often at a

loss to know how to cater to teachers' needs, and there is a lack of research on the topic. From the earliest studies focusing on the issue, it has been shown that (especially) content teachers (a) struggle to develop an identity as professionals charged with integrating content and language, (b) may have epistemological beliefs that hinder the development of such an identity, and (c) lack pedagogical content knowledge necessary for bringing about integration in their classrooms (Cammarata & Tedick, 2012; Tan, 2011). Seen from another perspective, it appears that, often, teachers lack the knowledge necessary to integrate language and content when this is demanded by the programme (such as immersion or CLIL), or to engage in language-sensitive teaching where the focus is purely on content taught through the medium of a second or foreign language (such as EAL or EMI).

If, as Ballinger et al. (2024) point out, teacher educators struggle to find ways of supporting teachers in developing the knowledge they need for CLI, it may be that they lack access to a knowledge base that could inform PD programmes. What this indicates is the need for a more fully-developed knowledge base for the integration of content and language across these educational contexts. It is true that recent years have seen a growth in conceptual frameworks which can be a basis for a more integrated approach. These include the 4Cs framework and the Language Triptych (Coyle et al., 2010), the Sheltered Instruction Observation Protocol (SIOP) model (Echevarria et al., 2016), the Contextualization, Awareness, Practice, and Autonomy (CAPA) model (Tedick & Lyster, 2019), the pluriliteracies approach (Coyle & Meyer, 2021), the Content-Language-Literacy Integration framework (Cammarata, 2016), and different adaptations of genre-based pedagogy (Lin, 2016; Llinares et al., 2012). However, the fact that such models exist does not mean that teachers around the world have access to them, or that even if they did, they would have the kind of PD they need to put any such models into practice.

Teacher language awareness for content and language integration (TLA for CLI)

At a more theoretical level, progress has been made on identifying the types of knowledge and awareness required and used by teachers for the integration of content, language, and literacy. Many studies have drawn on Shulman's (1987) seminal construct of pedagogical content knowledge (PCK), and more recent revisions and updates of the construct such as Loewenberg-Ball et al.'s (2008) construct of content knowledge for teaching. Troyan et al. (2017) proposed a model which they labelled integration pedagogical content knowledge (I–PCK), an extension of PCK that broadens the concept of content knowledge needed by teachers to successfully implement content-based instruction (CBI). This model has been further extended by Cammarata and Cavanagh (2018), who added the extra dimension of literacy to make it more relevant to immersion contexts. They aimed to build a knowledge base for immersion teaching by focusing on teachers' readiness to adopt an integrative approach.

Drawing on Loewenberg-Ball et al.'s (2008) content knowledge for teaching, Morton (2018) proposes that teachers who teach academic subjects through an L2 need to develop specific knowledge, which he labels language knowledge for content teaching (LKCT), which has two sub-components of common language knowledge for content teaching (CLK-CT) and specialized language knowledge for content teaching (SLK-CT). CLK-CT refers to the kinds of language knowledge, including general proficiency and the ability to use academic

language pertaining to the subject, that is not specifically required for the tasks of teaching. SLK-CT is knowledge of language that is held and deployed in teaching, such as selecting appropriate question types and scaffolding students' responses. Focusing specifically on the role of language in content pedagogy, Seah et al. (2022) propose a Language-Related Knowledge Base for Content Teaching (LRKCT), which consists of knowledge of language, knowledge about language, knowledge of students and pedagogical knowledge (including the sub-component knowledge of the role of language). They make the important point that the knowledge base proposed applies equally to both monolingual and multilingual classrooms, and that, as a consequence, LRKCT is required by all content teachers. Running in parallel to this research effort to delineate a broad pedagogical knowledge base for CLI, there has been a more specific focus on the construct of language awareness, specifically the type of teacher language awareness (TLA) which can form a foundation for effective CLI. Although both *Knowledge about Language* (KAL) and *Language Awareness* have been used to label a similar underlying construct (Cenoz & Gorter, 2017), it is useful to adopt the distinction the Association for Language Awareness (ALA) makes between the two terms. In this distinction, 'knowledge about language' is a component of the broader construct of Language Awareness, which is defined as 'explicit knowledge about language, and conscious perception and sensitivity in language learning, language teaching and language use' (ALA, n.d.). It is this broader construct which is the focus of the current Special Issue, that is, teachers' explicit knowledge about language (and literacy), and how they perceive and are sensitive to language learning, teaching and use, in the different contexts where CLI is at issue.

The fact that the ALA's definition includes the three dimensions of language learning, teaching, and use suggests that it draws on Edge's (1988) influential framework for conceptualizing knowledge about language and language learning for trainee language teachers. Edge describes the three key roles of language user, language analyst, and language teacher. The user role focuses on teachers' own use of the language for a range of pedagogical and other purposes. The analyst role refers to explicit knowledge about language, specifically the metalinguistic knowledge that enables them to have a deeper understanding of how language operates in what and how they teach. The teacher role takes in pedagogical knowledge about language, including the ability to maintain a language focus in planning, instruction, and assessment.

The most important contribution to conceptualizing TLA is found in the work of Andrews (e.g. 2007). In his model, language teacher language awareness (TLA) is a subcomponent of PCK and is manifested in teachers' own proficiency in using the language, their knowledge about the language as a subject, and their knowledge of learners as language learners. In this sense, the three components of Andrews' TLA can be mapped onto Edge's three roles of user, analyst, and teacher. Andrews (2007) also sees TLA as having declarative and procedural dimensions, that is, knowledge of language, and knowledge of how to put this knowledge into practice. In this model, the declarative aspect links more to 'knowledge', and the procedural aspect to 'awareness' (procedural), and it is awareness that allows teachers to deploy their knowledge with ease and fluency in teaching.

Turning to the specific issue of TLA for CLI, it has been for some time clear in the literature that such awareness goes beyond that required for teaching language as a subject, as in Andrews' model. Teachers responsible for CLI need to do a lot more than simply adding language knowledge to content knowledge (He & Lin, 2018). As Andrews and Lin (2017) point out, teachers in CLI contexts face many challenges, such as uncertainty about

programme goals, confusion about their own roles as either language teachers or content teachers or an amalgam of both, and a lack of language-oriented teaching materials.

Some of this confusion may arise from an insufficient understanding of the roles of language in content learning. Language is not simply a conduit or delivery system for already established content knowledge but is bound up with the way knowledge itself is created, constructed, and presented (Barwell, 2005; Halliday & Webster, 2004). This can be described as a social-semiotic view of CLI, in which language use is seen as meaning making as part of the social activity of the teaching and learning of academic subjects, and as such content and language are always already integrated. Drawing on this social semiotic perspective, Andrews and Lin (2017) propose that teachers in CLIL contexts should be aware of concepts like genre, register, and information density, and should be able to use these tools to analyse the linguistic features of the academic texts they use and teach. CLI teachers thus need to understand how language is involved in disciplinary learning, and how this presents opportunities and challenges for learners (Hu & Gao, 2021).

Fostering a deeper understanding of how language is implicated in disciplinary content learning, for example from a socio-semiotic perspective, can be seen as working on the 'analyst' domain of Edge's framework. Indeed, conceptualizations of TLA for CLI have drawn on this tridimensional framework, notably in the work of Lindahl and Watkins (2015) and Lindahl and Baecher (2016). Lindahl and Watkins (2015) use the three domains to make concrete proposals for the tasks of text and material selection, instructional planning, responsive teaching, and developing students' academic language. In a later study, Lindahl and Baecher (2016) use the three domains to investigate the development of TLA in TESOL teacher candidates and supervisors in CBI/CLIL contexts, with a specific focus on language-related responses in supervisors' feedback.

The early work by Lindahl and colleagues has been extended and developed by other researchers also seeking to use the user, analyst, and teacher domains to conceptualize and find ways to develop TLA for CLI, often in combination with Andrews' model. For example, two studies in the context of English-medium STEM secondary education in Hong Kong use these frameworks to investigate the TLA required by subject teachers for successful CLI. Xu and Harfitt (2019), in their study of Grade 7 science teachers, place emphasis on the 'teacher' domain, but shifting the focus from teachers to learners. They point out the importance of TLA for teachers' abilities to scaffold language learning, by using strategies such as mediation, eliciting higher order thinking by asking probing questions, and translating. In their study of four secondary teachers of mathematics and integrated science, Hu and Gao (2021) focus on the analyst and teacher domains by arguing that content teachers need to bring more focus on language forms (lexis, grammar, and genre structure) into their teaching, claiming that a failure to do so may have a negative effect on students' content learning.

Overview of the special issue

The studies briefly reviewed above may suggest to the reader how the phenomenon of TLA for CLI varies depending on the specific contexts and programme types. The papers in the current Special Issue are intended to explore TLA for CLI across a range of educational levels and settings, and thus highlighting how different educational environments shape the nature and extent of TLA. For example, TLA may be different in nature in 'hard' or 'soft' CLIL contexts (Ikeda et al., 2022). In 'hard' CLIL contexts, teachers are primarily responsible for

content teaching and learning, and their TLA may need to focus on the development of their students' disciplinary literacy, rather than on more general aspects of L2 development (that is, if there is any focus on language at all). In 'soft' CLIL, instruction is timetabled within language lessons, and the 'content' may be seen as an adjunct or simply a vehicle for language-learning goals. What teachers need to know and do about language (teaching) may differ in these contexts.

In immersion education programmes, the L2 will usually not be a 'foreign' language, but often a co-official language or one that is used by the local minority communities. In such contexts, teachers may require a specialized form of TLA that enables them to ensure content learning outcomes while focusing on the maintenance of the L2 in an environment where it is not the dominant language.

CLI may take place in settings which are considered more or less monolingual or multilingual. In multilingual settings (likely to be more prevalent around the world), TLA involves sensitivity to the plurilingual repertoires of students, including an awareness of how students' multiple languages can be leveraged as resources for learning both content and language, through such practices as translanguaging (Li, 2018). TLA for CLI is also shaped by the structure and content of teacher education programmes, although as Ballinger, Tedick et al. (2024) point out, there is a lack of such programmes for contexts such as immersion. Pre-service and in-service teacher education and PD should provide opportunities for teachers to develop both their explicit knowledge about language (analyst domain) and their practical ability to integrate language and content in the classroom (teacher domain). This involves moving from declarative knowledge about language to the procedural knowledge necessary for effective classroom practice.

The current Special Issue aims to contribute to the conceptualization and development of TLA for CLI and to show how the construct manifests across different contexts around the world. The papers all focus on the construct of TLA for CLI and cover educational levels from primary to tertiary, in different parts of the globe (North America, Latin America, Europe, and Asia). The papers cover the phenomenon of TLA for CLI from a wide range of disciplinary and methodological perspectives, with the aim of enabling the field to gain a clearer picture of what may be common to all the different contexts, while respecting the variety and diversity of the ways TLA for CLI is manifested in different geographical, social, cultural, and educational settings. The six papers cover the following topics and geographical areas: cross-curricular collaboration in English-medium schools in Hong Kong (Lo & Liang, 2024); CLIL teacher education in Latin America (Argentina, Ecuador, and Colombia) (Banegas & Arellano, 2024); CLIL training for English language teachers in Japan (de Boer & Leontjev, 2024; teacher (content and language)-researcher collaboration in bilingual education in Spain (Llinares et al., 2024; immersion teacher education in Canada (Ballinger, Cammarata et al., 2024); and, primary CLIL teacher education in the UK and the Netherlands (Rutgers, 2024).

In the first paper, Lo and Liang (2024) focus on secondary school content teachers in Hong Kong, exploring how TLA manifests in a 'hard' CLI context where the primary focus is on content instruction. The study highlights the importance of collaboration in the development of TLA for CLI. It shows that there is a reciprocal relationship between cross-curricular collaboration and TLA, in that collaboration can enhance teachers' awareness of the language demands of their subjects and, in turn, how it can facilitate more effective collaboration. The study identifies some challenges that content teachers face in developing TLA, particularly in relation to their epistemological beliefs and the integration of language objectives into content teaching.

The second paper by Banegas and Arellano (2024) looks into the development of TLA among pre-service teachers in Argentina, Colombia, and Ecuador. Their study is one of a growing number of studies which highlights the importance of teacher educators' own TLA in shaping the experiences of student teachers. The paper puts forward a pedagogical model for developing TLA for CLI in teacher education, which includes stages of exploration, inductive input, reflection, and informed use. The study also addresses the role of teacher identity in the development of TLA, particularly in relation to the distinction between language and content teacher identities.

In the third paper, DeBoer and Leontjev (2024) explore TLA in the context of Japanese CLIL programmes, which are characterized by a 'soft' CLIL approach in which there is a stronger focus on language development alongside content instruction. Drawing on the features of this type of context, they propose a construct of 'content knowledge for language teaching' (CKLT). They adopt a dialectical materialist epistemology to allow for simultaneously uncovering and provoking teacher development and discuss the interplay between declarative and procedural knowledge in TLA, emphasizing the need for teachers to develop both types of knowledge to effectively integrate language and content. Like Lo and Liang's (2024) paper, the study also highlights the importance of collaboration and reflection in the development of TLA, suggesting that these processes help to bridge the gap between theoretical knowledge and classroom practice.

The fourth paper by Llinares et al. (2024) shifts the focus to a European (Spanish) 'hard' CLIL context, where the integration of content and language has specific challenges due to the focus on content learning outcomes. In an in-service PD context, the study explores how TLA manifests in different stages of lesson planning, implementation, and assessment. Drawing on the sociological framework of Legitimation Code Theory (LCT), they propose a model that integrates cognitive (individual) and social (collaborative) perspectives on the development of TLA for CLI. The study also examines the tensions that can arise between content and language objectives, particularly in terms of how teachers navigate these competing demands in their instructional practices.

In the fifth paper, Ballinger, Cammarata et al. (2024) highlight the critical dimension of TLA for CLI, in the context of PD of immersion teachers in Canadian French immersion programs. The paper argues that Critical Language Awareness (CLA) is a crucial component of TLA, particularly in immersion contexts where teachers must navigate the complexities of content-language integration while also addressing issues of language maintenance and identity. Using data from university websites and focus groups, the study highlights the variation in how Canadian universities prepare teachers for immersion, pointing to the need for more consistent guidelines and standards for TLA in immersion teacher education.

The sixth and final paper, by Rutgers (2024), addresses the plurilingual and psycholinguistic dimensions of TLA for CLI in Dutch and UK primary school contexts, where teachers are respectively working with CLIL and EAL (English as an Additional Language) learners. The paper critiques and expands existing frameworks of TLA by incorporating a plurilingual perspective, arguing for the need for TPLA (teacher plurilingual awareness) and thus emphasizing the importance of understanding how multiple languages interact in the classroom. Rutgers also discusses the form-meaning distinction in TLA, arguing for a more integrated approach that considers both linguistic structures and their cognitive processing by students.

Across the diverse contexts explored in this Special Issue, several cross-cutting themes emerge that underscore the complexity of TLA for CLI and its critical role in different bilingual

education programmes. These themes are: The theoretical and practical dimensions of TLA for CLI; collaboration as a driver of TLA for CLI; epistemological beliefs and TLA for CLI; criticality in TLA for CLI; the plurilingual nature of TLA for CLI. These themes are briefly discussed below.

The relationship between theory and practice is a recurring theme in discussions of TLA. For instance, DeBoer and Leontjev (2024) emphasize the dialectical relationship between theoretical concepts of TLA and their practical application in the classroom. Teachers must not only understand the theory behind language and content integration but also be able to translate this understanding into effective teaching strategies. Indeed, one of the most significant challenges highlighted across the studies is the difficulty of translating theoretical knowledge about TLA into practical classroom strategies. This gap between theory and practice is evident in the struggles that pre-service teachers face in applying their knowledge of language to the design and implementation of content-integrated lessons (Banegas & Arellano, 2024) or how in-service teachers move from declarative to procedural knowledge in designing, implementing, and assessing (Llinares et al., 2024).

Collaboration between content and language teachers (and also researchers) is identified as a key factor in enhancing TLA. Lo and Liang (2024) argue that cross-curricular collaboration helps to develop a shared understanding of the language demands of different subjects, thereby enriching TLA. This reciprocal relationship suggests that collaboration is both a product and a facilitator of TLA. Llinares et al. (2024) show how TLA for CLI can be fostered through collaboration between not only content and language teachers, but also involving applied linguistics researchers.

Teachers' epistemological beliefs about language and content play a significant role in shaping their TLA for CLI. For example, the beliefs that content teachers hold about the nature of language can influence how they approach language integration in their teaching. Addressing these beliefs is crucial in teacher education programs to ensure that teachers are equipped with a robust TLA that supports effective content and language integration (Lo & Liang, 2024).

Critical language awareness (CLA) is a significant and possibly somewhat neglected aspect of TLA, particularly in contexts where language instruction intersects with issues of identity, power, and ideology. Ballinger et al. (2024) explore how criticality needs to be embedded in the TLA of immersion teachers, highlighting the importance of developing an awareness that goes beyond linguistic structures to include a critical understanding of language use in broader socio-cultural contexts. In line with this more critical component of TLA, there is also a need for greater awareness of the plurilingual nature of language competence. The fact that only one of the papers in the Special Issue (Rutgers, 2024) has a specific focus on this component highlights a growing need to shift away from monolingual conceptions of TLA.

Conclusion: developing and broadening the construct of TLA for CLI

The current Special Issue of *Language Awareness* provides a rich exploration of the construct of teacher language awareness for content and language integration (TLA for CLI) across a variety of bilingual education contexts. The papers collectively underscore the importance of TLA for effective content and language integration in both pre- and in-service contexts, across different types of programme (e.g. 'soft' and 'hard' versions of CLIL, EMI, and EAP) while also highlighting the challenges that teachers face in developing and applying this awareness in diverse classroom

settings. The insights gained from these studies have significant implications for teacher education, suggesting that a more nuanced and context-sensitive approach to TLA is needed to support teachers in their dual roles as language educators and content specialists.

In terms of developing and broadening the construct of TLA for CLIL, three areas emerge which would merit increased attention in future research. These are the need for a more critical sociolinguistic perspective on language use, the nature of language awareness as a plurilingual phenomenon, and the growing realization that disciplinary literacy is an essential component of TLA for CLI. The first two of these issues were explicitly addressed in two of the papers (Ballinger, Cammarata et al. and Rutgers, respectively) while the third was mostly addressed implicitly.

There is much scope for these issues to be addressed within the overarching framework of Andrews' conceptualization of TLA, linked with Edge's three domains of user, analyst, and teacher. This tridimensional perspective is flexible in that each domain can be 'filled out' in different ways, depending on whether the emphasis is on criticality, plurilingualism, or disciplinary literacy. Thus, for example, teachers can use a critical sociolinguistics perspective such as that seen in the work of Cushing (2020) to reflect on their own use of the language of instruction, to analyse the assumptions and expectations towards language standards in teaching materials, and to work out the implications for their own classroom teaching. Likewise, teachers can reflect on their own plurilinguistic competence, use knowledge of phenomena such as codeswitching and translanguaging to analyse multilingual texts and language production, and leverage such knowledge in pedagogical practices which draw on learners' entire linguistic repertoires. As for disciplinary literacy, teachers can work on and improve their own competences in using the target language for academic purposes, use conceptual tools such as genre and register to analyse the linguistic challenges of content topics and teaching materials, and find ways to foster disciplinary literacy in their teaching.

All three perspectives can be the topics of research studies such as the ones in this Special Issue which can combine other theoretical frameworks and use a range of methodological options to further develop and expand the construct of TLA for CLI. It is hoped that this Special Issue will act as a catalyst for further such studies.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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